

Chapter 110 - Reunion

No matter how thick the snow was, it would still melt away. This winter passed quietly as usual, followed by spring returning to the earth, awakening all slumbering life.

In three months' time, everything seemed to be the calm tranquility before a storm. Even the year's drought was temporarily ended by the heavy snow, with spring water flowing east in murmuring streams.

Immortal gates everywhere flourished like spring, busily preparing for the Demon-Slaying Conference. Some remote sects had already gathered their disciples and set off for Liugen Huayan Island¹.

Liugen Huayan Island was located in the Central Plains, not in the middle of the sea, but was an island floating above the clouds.

This place was once a divine miracle ten thousand years ago, and later used by various immortal gates and aristocratic families as a place for trade and gatherings. Even without hosting the Demon-Slaying Conference, it was already lively, but now with the conference, it was even more bustling than usual.

Due to Liugen Huayan Island's location, Xiangzhou City² below the island also became a gathering place for mortals and immortals. Though mostly inhabited by ordinary people, they had long grown accustomed to witnessing cultivators and continued to serve as a fortress city.

Just after Qingming Festival³, rain had knocked down the first batch of wild cherries, scattering them on the ground to be crushed by passing pedestrians and carriages. They quickly turned into fragrant mud and were swept away by servants, leaving the stone-paved streets clean once more.

Despite the drizzling rain outside that would break travelers' spirits, inside Xiangzhou City's largest tavern, "Flying Swallow Residence," it was full of spring atmosphere. The tavern was filled with peach blossom-scented incense, and the sound of a guqin⁴ flowed like a stream from behind embroidered screens, making people drowsy.

The door was pushed open, and several young men and women rushed in to escape the rain, all wearing white and blue clothes with identical white jade ornaments at their waists. They were led by servants to find seats.

"This weather changes every day. Just a few days ago it was so hot it could roast people, but after the Qingming rain, it's gotten chilly again." A young man with neatly combed hair sniffled and sneezed toward the ground.

A rosy-cheeked young woman handed him a handkerchief, saying sweetly: "I told you not to practice properly. Now you haven't even achieved grain avoidance⁵, so naturally you're afraid of the cold."

"I didn't... achoo!" The young man wanted to argue but bent down to blow his nose instead.

An older young woman nearby stopped their bickering, waving for a menu and ordering several cups of hot tea, reproaching them: "Enough! We finally got to come out with Master once - don't embarrass our Tianxuan Sword Sect."

The rosy-cheeked girl covered her mouth, laughing as she clung to the older girl: "Senior Sister Yantan, I heard that for this Demon-Slaying Conference, all famous and unknown cultivators have come, including that Divine Venerable Chu Qingqiu⁶ who twice slaughtered demon clans. Is this true?"

Zhou Yantan quickly used tea and snacks to block her mouth, looking around and reproaching: "How can you speak the Divine Venerable's name so casually? Even our Master Elder Songxiang must call her Grand-Master!"

She pushed the girl away and continued: "With such a grand occasion, all sect leaders will naturally attend. The Divine Venerable certainly won't be absent."

"Then I heard that Divine Venerable Chu Ling has a face like a celestial fairy, pure as ice and jade - is this true?" the girl asked again.

"How would I know? I only caught a distant glimpse at the Zhaoyao Conference thirty years ago, when I was about your age. How could I remember clearly?" Zhou Yantan pushed the hot tea toward her, deflecting: "Just drink your tea."

The girl had just reluctantly lowered her head to drink tea when the young man who had finished blowing his nose looked up and leaned over: "Senior Sister, Senior Sister, yesterday I heard a little monk from Kongming Sect say that this time for the Demon-Slaying Conference, the legendary demons from Cuwei Hall⁷ really came. Is this true?"

Zhou Yantan couldn't drink her tea anymore and sighed, putting it down on the table: "Yesterday I also heard Master mention it once. It shouldn't be false."

"But wasn't our Demon-Slaying Conference originally held to eliminate those demon clans? Do they really have such courage to appear so brazenly? And how would the Six Gates⁸ allow it?" The young man slapped the table.

"Keep your voice down." Zhou Yantan, worn out by their pestering, gave him a knock on the head: "That Cuwei Hall is full of demons is just a rumor. No one has ever caught them, and the Six Gates have no evidence - how can they arbitrarily convict people?"

"Moreover, this Cuwei Hall appears and disappears like ghosts. They only sent an invitation to our sect, but where they come from and whether they'll actually come is unknown."

"Oh, don't worry about it." The tea-drinking girl swallowed the tea in her mouth and glanced sideways at the young man. "Not only will the Six Great Sects and Four Great Families be present that day, but also Penglai. Penglai are all demigods - their strength is far superior to that Cuwei Hall. Nothing will go wrong."

"Even if Cuwei Hall really are all demons, it would be perfect to catch them all at once. I'd enjoy watching the show!"

Zhou Yantan sighed deeply: "Enough! Even food can't block your mouths!"

The hall looked empty and deserted, and the young people were too inexperienced to realize their entire conversation had been overheard.

Behind the screen, a song ended. The woman playing the qin put away her instrument, nodded to the next musician, then carried her qin up the stairs behind the screen to the top floor.

She swayed gracefully, wearing a bright blue dress with exotic charm. Her waist and neck were fully exposed, her milk-white skin adorned with broken silver chains, making her body look as soft as dough, ready to break at a touch.

She knocked on a door, ignored the black face of the person who opened it, shoved the qin into her hands, and walked with fragrant wind to the far end of the room, prostrating half-kneeling on a couch.

"Hall Master, let this servant do it." She said, taking over the half-peeled lychee from the woman's hands, carefully peeling it open with her delicate fingers that had just played the qin.

Half-reclining on the couch was none other than Ning Fuyi. She had now returned to her original appearance, not the face from the demon realm, her phoenix eyes half-closed as she listened to the music.

Her black robes hung in layers beside the jade couch, her skin so white it didn't seem human, yet her red lips were moist, unlike a ghost.

Silver bells hung at her waist but made no sound. A jade-colored small sword hung from her neck with the characters "Xiangsi⁹" written on it. Black rings on her fingers circulated with faint lightning.

Her face bore no cosmetics, only a dot of cinnabar between her brows, softening the coldness on her face and adding some seductive charm.

The woman peeling lychees for her looked at this face, a barely perceptible greed arising in her eyes. She then picked up the round, jade-like fruit and brought it to her lips.

"Ah..." she said softly.

This sound made Hancrow at the door break out in goosebumps. Unable to bear it any longer, she rushed forward to hit someone, but was held back by Xique behind her.

"Deep breaths! This person is useful to Master - we can't kill her!" Xique counseled in her ear.

Hancrow angrily pinched her own philtrum, imitating the woman's affected manner: "I can't stand it anymore! I've never been that close to Master, and she's going 'ah, ah, ah' - what the hell!"

"Shh shh shh!" Xique covered her mouth and pulled her back to calm her down. "Cool down."

"Think about it - Master's persona now is the libertine Hall Master of Cuwei Hall. She needs people to serve her. If not this one, it would be more beauties and handsome men. Would you rather watch one Du Baishuang¹⁰, or a bunch of beautiful men?" Xique whispered.

Hancrow touched her chin thoughtfully, then nodded in agreement: "One is better then!"

"Exactly." Xique smiled and patted her. "Just bear with it."

The two spoke without concealment. Ning Fuyi heard everything clearly with her eyes closed and found it amusing, but didn't acknowledge them. Instead, she opened her mouth and bit the lychee with her pearly teeth.

Sweet juice burst in her mouth, delicious and flavorful.

Du Baishuang stared at her lips holding the lustrous white lychee, then rolling it to her tongue tip, saying nothing as she lowered her head to continue peeling.

Du Baishuang had reappeared before her two years ago, when she had once again gotten herself into dire straits, cornered by a group of Eastern Mountain people who nearly tore her apart. She was rescued by Hancrow who happened to pass by and brought before her.

According to what she said, she had originally returned to Tianshan, but those secretly hunting spirit clans still hadn't let her go. Forced to flee to the foot of the mountain, she ran into Hancrow.

Ning Fuyi, remembering their past relationship from the previous life, gave her a new identity, letting her join Cuwei Hall, hide in Xiangzhou City, and work as the manager of Flying Swallow Residence to gather information from passing travelers.

Now, she was proving quite useful.

Du Baishuang was about to feed her more, but Ning Fuyi raised her hand to stop her.

"Too much sweetness becomes cloying." Ning Fuyi said, opening the window to look outside.

Outside was the main road entering Xiangzhou City, mostly filled with carriages and few pedestrians. Even those present wore rain capes, making them hard to see clearly.

However, among them stood out a man in light blue cloth robes. He was tall but thin, carrying a bow on his back that seemed very heavy, bending his spine.

He appeared to be fleeing from pursuers, running in panic. His pursuers soon appeared - several young men and women in brown and white sect robes, continuously mocking and laughing, as if watching his humiliation.

When she saw the lotus wood carving hanging at the man's waist, Ning Fuyi's hand gripping the window suddenly tightened, leaving two finger marks in the rosewood window frame.

It was Rong Jin¹¹!

She had long known that Rong Jin wasn't dead. Though she felt relieved and had secretly visited to check on him, she never dared appear before him.

Not only because she feared bringing him trouble, but also because she had already proclaimed herself Demon Venerable in the demon realm. Rong Jin despised evil, and she didn't dare let him know that the person he had desperately saved had ultimately still chosen the demonic path.

Moreover, the blow he had taken for her thirty years ago, though not fatal, had wasted decades of his cultivation and even damaged half his immortal meridians.

Though Rong Jin still struggled with cultivation, he was now considered a waste in the immortal gates' eyes, unable to achieve the great path again.

Watching Rong Jin being cornered into a street alley by those people, Ning Fuyi's heart tightened. She quickly moved to follow.

However, getting up, she felt her current appearance too demon-like. She flicked her fingers, and her clothes instantly switched with Hancrow's, changing into ordinary cloth robes.

Short Hancrow was suddenly covered by Ning Fuyi's robes. After struggling for a while with Xique's help to get her head out, she called for her master, but Ning Fuyi had already disappeared.

She quickly appeared in the cold, damp alley, with slippery moss under her feet.

Looking sideways, the thin man had been cornered against the wall, surrounded by several people carrying swords.

The leader had thick eyebrows and big eyes, a high nose bridge, and wore a lotus flower crown on his head. Though dressed properly, his expression showed unruliness.

He spat out a fruit pit from his mouth and threw it at Rong Jin, mocking: "Isn't this Senior Brother Rong Jin who defeated me thirty years ago? How has your courage gotten so small? Not only do you not act arrogant when you see me, but you actually run away like a mouse?"

"Could it be because your Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate has fallen, and knowing no one backs you up, you don't dare provoke me anymore?" The man grinned, showing white teeth.

Rong Jin used his sleeve to block the fruit pit thrown at him, his handsome face filled with anger: "Hua Feiwu¹², don't go too far!"

"Hey, a grown man acting so coy - if you don't dare fight, just kneel and beg for mercy. We won't bully the weak." Another man laughed.

Then he kicked, splashing mud and water all over Rong Jin.

Rong Jin was so angry his teeth clenched. He reached back to grip his bow and arrow, but his wrist trembled uncontrollably.

"That's right! Today I want to have a proper fight with you, to see if you can still defeat me!" Hua Feiwu sneered, suddenly drawing his long sword from his waist. The sword was immediately wrapped in blazing fire as he viciously slashed toward Rong Jin's head.

Seeing Rong Jin unable to defend himself, Ning Fuyi quickly leaped from the wall corner, about to intervene when she suddenly heard fierce wind howling. At the same time, a tremendous crash brought down courtyard walls.

She quickly withdrew her immortal power and looked up to see a pure white figure leap through the air, landing heavily between the two men.

Footnotes:

- ¹ **Liugen Huayan Island (六根华严岛)** - The location where the Demon-Slaying Conference will be held
- ² **Xiangzhou City (相州城)** - The city below the floating island that serves as a gathering point
- ³ **Qingming Festival (清明)** - A traditional Chinese festival for honoring ancestors, usually in early April
- ⁴ **Guqin (古琴)** - A traditional Chinese seven-stringed musical instrument
- ⁵ **Grain avoidance (辟谷)** - A cultivation practice where advanced practitioners no longer need to eat regular food
- ⁶ **Divine Venerable Chu Qingqiu (褚清秋神尊)** - Chu Qingqiu's formal title as a high-ranking cultivator
- ⁷ **Cuwei Hall (懋畏堂)** - The mysterious organization led by Ning Fuyi in her demon identity
- ⁸ **Six Gates (六派)** - Refers to the six major righteous cultivation sects
- ⁹ **Xiangsi (相思)** - Meaning "lovesickness" or "yearning," the name of Ning Fuyi's sword
- ¹⁰ **Du Baishuang (杜白双)** - The spirit clan woman serving Ning Fuyi, whose name literally means "White Frost"
- ¹¹ **Rong Jin (容锦)** - A former friend of Ning Fuyi from Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate
- ¹² **Hua Feiwu (花非雾)** - The antagonist confronting Rong Jin, whose name means "Flower Not Mist"